Earth's Tiny New Mini-Moon Is Staying for Christmas

From: Space.com Mined: 2026-11-06 3 min read

Earth has a new tiny neighbor for the holidays: 2026 QQ8, a space rock only about 6 feet wide. Scientists saw it in August 2026, after Earth's **gravity** caught it in April 2026. The International **Astronomical** Union's Minor Planet Center shared the news on October 29.

QQ8 is called a **mini-moon** because it is **circling** Earth for a short visit. It will stay through December, then drift away in early 2027. Its trip around the sun takes 359 days, or about 0.98 of an Earth year. It swings close to Earth once every ten years.

At its closest, QQ8 will pass about 353,000 miles from Earth, about 110,000 miles farther than the average distance to the moon. Do not worry: even if it headed for Earth, it would likely burn up in the air first.

QQ8 is not the first **mini-moon**. Research last year said Earth could have as many as six at one time, and many may be pieces of our own moon. The average **mini-moon** is about 75 **centimeters** wide, or 30 inches, and stays nine months.

Word Treasure

mini-moon -- A mini-moon is a small space rock that circles Earth for a short visit.
gravity -- Gravity is the pull that holds things toward Earth.
Astronomical -- Astronomical means having to do with stars, planets, and space.
circling -- Circling means moving around something in a round path.
centimeters -- Centimeters are small units used to measure how long or wide something is.

Background you need

A mini-moon is a small space rock that Earth's gravity catches for a short time, so it circles our planet like a tiny extra moon.

Most mini-moons are very small and stay only a few months before drifting away again.

Some of them may be pieces of our own moon that broke off long ago.

Break it down

WHO: 2026 QQ8, a space rock only about 6 feet wide, and the scientists and the International Astronomical Union's Minor Planet Center who spotted and shared it.

WHAT: Earth caught a tiny space rock that is circling our planet as a mini-moon for a short holiday visit.

WHERE: In space around Earth, passing about 353,000 miles away at its closest.

WHY: Earth's gravity caught QQ8 in April 2026, pulling it into a short orbit before it drifts away in early 2027.

Why it matters

It shows kids that Earth can catch its own tiny space visitor for the holidays, like a surprise guest staying through Christmas.

Test what you remember

1. How wide is the space rock 2026 QQ8?

- (A) About 60 feet
- (B) About 6 miles
- (C) About 6 feet
- (D) About 600 feet

2. When did Earth's gravity catch QQ8?

- (A) October 2026
- (B) December 2026
- (C) August 2026
- (D) April 2026

3. When will QQ8 drift away from Earth?

- (A) In ten years
- (B) In nine months
- (C) In early 2027
- (D) In August 2026

4. How long does QQ8's trip around the sun take?

- (A) Nine months
- (B) Exactly one Earth year
- (C) About 0.98 of an Earth year, or 359 days
- (D) Ten years

5. How often does QQ8 swing close to Earth?

- (A) Once every year
- (B) Once every 359 days
- (C) Once every month
- (D) Once every ten years

6. At its closest, how far from Earth will QQ8 pass?

- (A) About 110,000 miles
- (B) About 75 centimeters
- (C) About 30 inches
- (D) About 353,000 miles

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: C 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):